



Rintu Thomas and Sushmit Ghosh



DOCUMENTARIES

With Truth and Dare

A new age of Indian documentary filmmaking has dawned and it is taking the world by storm





Shaunak Sen
(Director)

The stars seem to have aligned for India's documentary filmmakers of late. In the last week of January, Shaunak Sen's *All That Breathes* picked up the World Cinema Grand Jury Prize (Documentary) at the Sundance Film Festival 2022. A week later, Rintu Thomas and Sushmit Ghosh's *Writing with Fire* (2021) became India's first documentary to be nominated at the Oscars. Thomas shared a clip on Twitter of Ghosh and herself listening to the nominations in real time. The disbelief and joy on their faces were altogether disarming. As Vinay Shukla, co-director of *An Insignificant Man* (2016), says. "It's been a long time coming!"

This recent euphoria doesn't, of course, negate an obvious fact—Indian non-fiction has been building up to a month like this. Anand Patwardhan's *Vivek* (English title: *Reason*) picked up the top prize at International Documentary Film Festival Amsterdam (IDFA) only in 2018. But taking on the mantle from the likes of Patwardhan, Sanjay Kak or Lalit and Nilita Vachani is a new guard of filmmakers who seem assured enough to play with the form of non-fiction to yield newer, different and interesting results.

Shaunak Sen's *All That Breathes*, for instance, follows the lives of two brothers and a young helper in East Delhi who help mend injured kites. The film begins with an exquisitely framed shot of rats in a garbage dump. Unlike his debut *Cities of Sleep* (2015), which adopted a hand-held vérité style, Sen wanted to try something different in his second film: "We wanted a more controlled, aestheticised framed kind of a style, something fluid. Thankfully, there was a cyclical nature to our days, so we could prepare our frames beforehand. I love this space of creative documentaries—using tools of fiction to shoot documentaries."